

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ
دار الإفتاء النور

جمعية إشاعة أهل السنة
(باكستان)

THE SHARĪ'AH RULING ON VEGETARIANISM AND VEGANISM

The Question (al-Istiftā’):

A **vegetarian** is a person who does not eat meat, chicken or fish, but does consume milk and eggs.

A **vegan** is one who gives up milk, eggs, honey and all other animal-derived foods along with meat.

1. Is it permissible for a Muslim to do this?
2. If someone gives up meat out of pity for animals, or for reasons of health or the environment, what is the ruling?
3. Is giving up meat permanently contrary to the Sunnah or makrūh?
4. And if a person considers the very act of slaughtering an animal for food to be wrong, what is the ruling on this view of his?
5. Also, some people nowadays say that Sayyidunā ‘Umar (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu) forbade meat; that there was little meat on the dining cloth of the Holy Prophet ﷺ, so his normal practice was to abstain from it; and that the Qur’ān has called animals "communities like you." What is the truth about these claims?

Bayyinū tu’jarū: kindly explain, and may you be rewarded.

(Questioner: Muhammad ‘Umar Fārūq, Boston, USA)

باسمہ تعالیٰ وتقّدر الجواب

In answering these questions, one point must first be understood. According to Islam – the religion of *fiṭra* (natural disposition), ḥalāl meat, milk, eggs and honey are all **mubāḥ** (permissible) foods and wholesome blessings.

To abstain from all or some of them, (i.e. not to eat them), is one thing; but to consider them ḥarām is quite another.

From this basic point and distinction, **four broad cases** arise:

First Case (*When Abstaining from Meat Becomes Farḍ i.e. Obligatory*)

A Muslim in a non-Muslim country who is **certain** that the **meat on sale is not ḥalāl** (lawful) must refrain from it.

This includes meat from **animals slaughtered by machine**, not slaughtered by proper dhabḥ (Islamic slaughter), or slaughtered by someone whose dhabīḥa (slaughtered animal) is not lawful. **Such meat is maytah (carrion) and ḥarām (forbidden)**, so **avoiding it is farḍ** (obligatory), not a personal choice.

Properly slaughtered ḥalāl meat stays lawful, including packed meat from a verified Muslim company whose genuine packaging can be recognised.

Second case: (*not a sin*)

A person who does not eat meat or other animal foods **because of his own temperament, taste, health, a doctor's advice, financial hardship or concern for the environment**, while at heart he regards them as ḥalāl, commits no sin. **Because if Allah has made something ḥalāl, that does not require every person to eat it necessarily.**

Third case: (*contrary to the Sunnah and prohibited*)

A person who gives up meat permanently, regarding its abandonment as part of religion, worship, *zuhd* (asceticism) or piety, is acting contrary to the Sunnah, and this is prohibited in the Sharī'ah. It is the very *rahbāniyyah* (monasticism) that the Holy Prophet ﷺ plainly forbade.

Fourth case: (*outright wrong and a statement of kufr*)

A person who considers the meat of ḥalāl animals or animal foods to be ḥarām in the Sharī'ah, or declares the very slaughter of an animal for food to be "cruelty and a crime", holds a view that is outright wrong and constitutes kufr.

Since the **permissibility of slaughtered animals (dhabīḥah)**, the **legitimacy of Qurbānī** in the religion, and its being the sunnah of the noble Prophets (‘alayhimus-salām) are **established by definitive (qaṭ‘ī) evidence from the Qur’ān, Sunnah and Ijmā‘**, and are among the **ḍarūriyyāt al-dīn (matters of the religion known to every Muslim)**, whoever says this, knowing that Islam

has made it ḥalāl and with no sound meaning to his words, becomes a kāfir. He must repent and renew his faith (tajdīd al-īmān), and if he is married, he must also renew his marriage (tajdīd al-nikāḥ).

However, this ruling is not to be applied to any particular individual without knowing his exact words and intention. A person who, on seeing slaughter, merely feels natural fear or distress and does not consider it impermissible falls under the second case. Likewise, one who means that he has made meat unlawful for himself, or who only condemns the cruelty of factory farming, has a different ruling and does not fall under this fourth case.

Other categories:

One major reason that has come to light for young people becoming vegan or vegetarian is their **opposition to factory farming**, and to **animals being raised and slaughtered with cruelty**.

On this, **the position of Islam is clear: keeping animals in cramped places, causing them unnecessary suffering during transport, leaving them hungry or thirsty, or causing needless pain during slaughter are prohibited practices.** Certain unnecessary practices in slaughter are specifically considered *makrūh*, as explained in the reference to *al-Hidāyah* below. **These wrong practices do not, however, make the meat of an otherwise lawful animal ḥarām.**

Environmental concerns also call for responsible use of resources. **The Sharī'ah forbids *isrāf* (extravagance and waste) and teaches moderation in the use and consumption of the blessings and resources of this world.**

Therefore, **the Islamic solution is to correct these wrong practices: to observe *iḥsān* (kindness and excellence) in slaughter, avoid waste and harm, and practise moderation in eating.** The solution is **not to abandon meat altogether or declare its consumption inherently cruel or unethical.**

References and Citations (for scholars and students of knowledge)

Allah سبحانه وتعالى says in the Qur'an:

﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تَحْرِمُوا طَيِّبَاتِ مَا أَحَلَّ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ وَلَا تَعْتَدُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يُحِبُّ الْمُعْتَدِينَ﴾
(المائدة: ٥/٨٧)

Translation: "O you who believe! Do not declare unlawful the pure things that Allah has made lawful for you, and do not exceed the limits. Indeed, those who exceed the limits are disliked by Allah." (*Kanz al-Īmān*)

Regarding the occasion of revelation (*shān-e nuzūl*) of the verse above, ‘Allāma Aḥmad ibn ‘Alī Abū Bakr **al-Jaṣṣāṣ al-Rāzī al-Ḥanafī** (raḥimahullāh, d. 370 AH) writes:

"وَرَوَى سَعِيدٌ عَنْ قَتَادَةَ قَالَ: كَانَ نَاسٌ مِنْ أَصْحَابِ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ ﷺ هُمُوا يَتْرَكُ اللَّحْمَ وَالنِّسَاءَ وَالْإِخْتِصَاءَ، فَأَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تُحَرِّمُوا طَيِّبَاتِ مَا أَحَلَّ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ﴾ الْآيَةَ، فَبَلَغَ ذَلِكَ النَّبِيَّ ﷺ فَقَالَ: لَيْسَ فِي دِينِي تَرْكُ النِّسَاءِ وَلَا اللَّحْمِ وَلَا اتِّخَاذُ الصَّوَامِعِ."

(*Aḥkām al-Qur’ān* by al-Jaṣṣāṣ, al-‘Ilmiyya edition, vol. 2, Sūrat al-Mā’ida, 2/565. Dār al-Kutub al-‘Ilmiyya, Beirut, Lebanon, 1st ed., 1415 AH / 1994 CE)

Translation:

Ḥaḍrat Qatāda (raḥimahullāh) says that some Companions of the Messenger of Allah ﷺ resolved to give up meat and women and to castrate themselves. So Allah (سبحانه و تعالى) revealed this verse: (O you who believe! Do not declare unlawful the pure things Allah has made lawful for you). When this reached the **Holy Prophet** ﷺ, he said:

"In my religion there is no giving up of women, nor of meat, nor retreating into places of worship like monks."

Imām Abu al-Ḥusayn **Muslim** ibn al-Ḥajjāj al-Qushayrī al-Naysābūrī (raḥimahullāh, d. 261 AH) narrates, with his chain of transmission, from **Sayyidunā Anas ibn Mālīk** (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhū):

"أَنَّ نَفَرًا مِنْ أَصْحَابِ النَّبِيِّ ﷺ سَأَلُوا أَزْوَاجَ النَّبِيِّ ﷺ عَنْ عَمَلِهِ فِي السِّرِّ، فَقَالَ بَعْضُهُمْ: لَا أَتَزَوَّجُ النِّسَاءَ، وَقَالَ بَعْضُهُمْ: لَا أَكُلُ اللَّحْمَ، وَقَالَ بَعْضُهُمْ: لَا أَنَامُ عَلَى فِرَاشٍ. فَحَمَدَ اللَّهُ وَأَثْنَى عَلَيْهِ فَقَالَ: مَا بَالُ أَقْوَامٍ قَالُوا كَذَا وَكَذَا؟ لَكِنِّي أَصْلِي وَأَنَامُ، وَأَصُومُ وَأُفْطِرُ، وَأَتَزَوَّجُ النِّسَاءَ، فَمَنْ رَغِبَ عَنْ سُنَّتِي فَلَيْسَ مِنِّي."

(*Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim*, ed. ‘Abd al-Bāqī, Kitāb al-Nikāḥ, Bāb Istihbāb al-Nikāḥ li-man Tāqat Nafsuhi ilayhi wa Wajada Mu’natahu, wa Ishtighāl man ‘Ajaza ‘an al-Mu’an bi-l-Ṣawm, ḥadīth no. 1401, 2/1020. Maṭba‘at ‘Īsā al-Bābī al-Ḥalabī wa Shurakāh, Cairo, 1374 AH / 1955 CE)

Translation:

"A few Companions asked the wives of the Holy Prophet ﷺ about the Holy Prophet's ﷺ practice when alone. (On hearing it,) one of them said, 'I will not marry.' Another said, 'I will not eat meat.' Another said, 'I will not sleep on a bed.' The Prophet ﷺ praised and glorified Allah, then said: 'What is the matter with people who say such-and-such? As for me, I pray and I also sleep; I fast and I also break my fast; and I also marry. So whoever turns away from my Sunnah is not of me.'"

This ḥadīth shows that those **Companions wished to give up ḥalāl things in order to withdraw from the world** and devote more time to worship, not because they thought these things impermissible or cruel. **Even so, they were forbidden from doing it.**

According to the commentators on ḥadīth,

"Sunnah" in this ḥadīth means the way of the Holy Prophet ﷺ, not the technical term Sunnah as opposed to *fard*. Turning away from the Sunnah means that a person deliberately abandons it and does not accept it as the way of the Prophet ﷺ.

At this point the scholars have also made clear that true virtue lies in following the Prophet ﷺ, not in deeming some particular manner or form of worship superior by one's own opinion.

(*Fath al-Bārī bi-Sharḥ al-Bukhārī*, Kitāb al-Nikāḥ, Bāb al-Targhīb fi al-Nikāḥ, 9/105–106. al-Maktaba al-Salafiyya, Egypt, 1st ed., 1380–1390 AH),

(*Riyāḍ al-Ṣāliḥīn*, Bāb fi al-Iqtiṣād fi al-ʿIbāda, p. 66. Dār Ibn Kathīr, Damascus and Beirut, 1st ed., 1428 AH / 2007 CE),

(*Fath al-Qadīr* by al-Kamāl ibn al-Humām, Kitāb al-Nikāḥ, 3/188. Sharikat Maktabat wa Maṭbaʿat Muṣṭafā al-Bābī al-Ḥalabī wa Awlādih, Egypt, 1st ed., 1389 AH / 1970 CE)

Therefore, a person who does not eat some ḥalāl thing merely out of temperament or for some worldly reason does not come under this warning. Otherwise, everyone who happens to dislike some ḥalāl food would be included in it, and that is plainly not correct.

Now citing the **Holy Prophet's** ﷺ **own practice**

Imām Abū 'Īsā Muḥammad ibn 'Īsā **al-Tirmidhī** (raḥimahullāh, d. 279 AH) narrates, with his chain of transmission, from **Sayyidunā Abū Hurayra** (raḍiyallāhu 'anhu):

"أَتَى النَّبِيَّ ﷺ بِلَحْمٍ فَرَفَعَ إِلَيْهِ الذَّرَاعُ، وَكَانَتْ تَعْجِبُهُ، فَهَسَّ مِنْهَا."

(*al-Shamā'il al-Muḥammadiyya* by al-Tirmidhī, Bāb mā Jā'a fī Ṣifat Idām Rasūl Allāh ﷺ, ḥadīth no. 168, p. 140. al-Maktaba al-Tijāriyya, Muṣṭafā Aḥmad al-Bāz, Makkah al-Mukarrama, 1st ed., 1413 AH / 1993 CE)

Translation:

Meat was brought to the Holy Prophet ﷺ and the foreleg was handed up to him. He liked the foreleg, so he ate from it.

In case a person declares some ḥalāl thing unlawful for himself alone

'Allāma Aḥmad ibn 'Alī Abū Bakr **al-Jaṣṣāṣ al-Rāzī al-Ḥanafī** (raḥimahullāh, d. 370 AH) writes at the same place:

"وَفَرَّقَ أَصْحَابُنَا بَيْنَ مَنْ قَالَ: «وَاللَّهِ لَا أَكُلُ هَذَا الطَّعَامَ» وَبَيْنَ قَوْلِهِ: «حَرَّمْتُهُ عَلَى نَفْسِي»، فَقَالُوا فِي التَّحْرِيمِ: إِنْ أَكَلَ الْجُزْءَ مِنْهُ حَنْثٌ، وَفِي الْإِيمَانِ لَا يَحْنُثُ إِلَّا بِأَكْلِ الْجَمِيعِ."

(*Aḥkām al-Qur'ān* by al-Jaṣṣāṣ, Sūrat al-Mā'ida, 2/565. Dār al-Kutub al-'Ilmiyya, Beirut, Lebanon, 1st ed., 1415 AH / 1994 CE)

Translation:

"Our Ḥanafī scholars have distinguished between the person who says, 'By Allah, I will not eat this food,' and the person who says, 'I have made it unlawful for myself.' They said: where he has declared it unlawful, his oath is broken if he eats even a little of it; whereas with an explicit oath, it is not broken until he eats all of it."

Therefore, **if someone has said, "I have made meat unlawful for myself," meat has not become ḥarām for him. Rather, this takes the ruling of an oath.** He should eat what is ḥalāl and pay the expiation (kaffāra) for the oath, and he should not go on believing it to be ḥarām for him.

The Ruling on Regarding the ḥalāl as ḥarām

'Allāma Zayn al-Dīn ibn Ibrāhīm, known as **Ibn Nujaym al-Miṣrī al-Ḥanafī** (raḥimahullāh, d. 970 AH), writes:

"وَالْأَصْلُ أَنَّ مَنْ اعْتَقَدَ الْحَرَامَ حَلَالًا، فَإِنْ كَانَ حَرَامًا لِغَيْرِهِ كَمَالِ الْغَيْرِ لَا يَكْفُرُ، وَإِنْ كَانَ لِعَيْنِهِ فَإِنْ كَانَ دَلِيلُهُ قَطْعِيًّا كَفَرَ، وَإِلَّا فَلَا."

(*al-Baḥr al-Rā'iq Sharḥ Kanz al-Daqā'iq*, Kitāb al-Siyar, Bāb Aḥkām al-Murtaddīn, 5/132. Dār al-Kitāb al-Islāmī, 2nd ed.)

Translation:

"The principle is that when someone believes a ḥarām thing to be ḥalāl: if the thing was ḥarām because of something else (*li-ghayrihi*), not in itself, such as another person's property, he does not become a *kāfir*. If it was ḥarām in itself (*li-ʿaynihi*), then it will be examined: if its prohibition is established by a definitive proof, he becomes a *kāfir*; otherwise not."

The reason for this ruling is that a definitive proof concerning the ḥalāl and the ḥarām is being rejected.

This applies to our issue as follows:

The Ummah is unanimous (ijmāʿ) that luḥūm al-anʿām (the meat of ḥalāl livestock such as camels, cattle and goats) is permissible and lawful, and this matter is among the ḍarūriyyāt al-dīn (matters of the religion known to every Muslim). Therefore, whoever calls slaughter itself cruelty and a crime is rejecting a definitive ruling, and this is contrary to faith.

(**Ibn al-Mundhir**, *al-Ijmāʿ*, ed. **Fuʾād**, Kitāb al-Aṭʿimah wa al-Ashribah, p. 131, Dār al-Muslim li al-Nashr wa al-Tawzīʿ, 1st ed. (Dār al-Muslim), 1425 AH / 2004 CE);

(**al-Kāsānī**, *Badāʾiʿ al-Ṣanāʾiʿ fī Tartīb al-Sharāʾiʿ*, Kitāb al-Dhabāʾiḥ wa al-Ṣuyūd, al-Maʾkūl wa Ghayr al-Maʾkūl min al-Ḥayawānāt, 5/37, Maṭbaʿat al-Jamāliyyah, Egypt, 1st ed., 1327-1328 AH)

Faqīh-e-Aʿzam-e-Hind, Shāriḥ-e-Bukhārī Muftī Sharīf al-Ḥaqq Amjadī (raḥimahullāh, d. 1421 AH) writes:

"Ḍarūriyyāt al-dīn: The term ḍarūriyyāt al-dīn that occurs in the definition of īmān refers to those religious matters whose belonging to the religion is established by such definitive and certain evidence that there is not an iota of doubt in it, and whose being a religious matter is known to everyone, learned and lay alike.

By the learned (khawāṣṣ) is meant the scholars, and by laypeople (ʿawāmm) is meant those who are not scholars but live in the company of scholars.

On this basis, religious matters that everyone knows to be part of the religion, but whose proof is not definitive, are not among the ḍarūriyyāt al-dīn, for example

the punishment of the grave and the weighing of deeds.

Likewise, matters whose proof is definitive, but whose belonging to the religion is not known to all, lay and learned, are also not among the *ḍarūriyyāt al-dīn*, for example that if there is a son's daughter along with the deceased's own daughters, the son's daughter receives one-sixth [i.e., alongside a single daughter, who takes one-half].

As for religious matters whose proof is definitive but which are not among the *ḍarūriyyāt al-dīn*: if the one who denies them knows that their proof is definitive, he is a *kāfir*. If he does not know, he should be told. If he accepts the truth on being told, he is a Muslim, and if he still denies it after being told, he is a *kāfir* (Shāmī, vol. 3, p. 309).

As for matters that everyone knows to be part of the religion but whose proof is not definitive, the one who denies them is not a *kāfir*. If these matters are among the *ḍarūriyyāt* of the Ahl al-Sunnah school, he is misguided (*gumrah*), and if they are not even that, he is mistaken (*khāṭi*).

Ḍarūriyyāt of the Ahl al-Sunnah school: the *ḍarūriyyāt* of the Ahl al-Sunnah school means matters whose belonging to the Ahl al-Sunnah school is known to all of the Ahl al-Sunnah, lay and learned, such as these same examples, the punishment of the grave and the weighing of deeds." (**Nuzhat al-Qārī Sharḥ Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī**, Kitāb al-Īmān, 1/294, Farid Book Stall, Lahore, 2nd edition, 1428 AH / 2007 CE)

Imām of the Ahl al-Sunnah, Imām Aḥmad Riḍā Khān al-Qādirī al-Ḥanafī al-Māturīdī (rahimahullāh, d. 1340 AH) writes:

"والمحققون لا يكفرون إلا بإنكار ما علم من الدين ضرورةً، بحيث يشترك في معرفته الخاص والعلم المخالطون للخاص، فإن كان المجمع عليه هكذا كفر منكراً، وإلا لا. ولا حاجة عندهم أيضاً إلى وجود نص؛ فإن كثيراً من ضروريات الدين مما لا نص عليه."

(**al-Mu'taqad al-Muntaqad ma'a Ḥāshiyatihi al-Mu'tamad al-Mustanad**, p. 316, Dār Ahl al-Sunnah, Karachi, 1443 AH / 2022 CE)

Translation:

"The meticulous or *taḥqīq* scholars (*al-muḥaqqiqūn*) do not declare anyone a *kāfir* except for denying what is known from the religion by necessity (*ḍarūrat*), meaning that the "learned" and "the laypeople who mix with the learned" all share in knowing it. So if the matter of consensus (*al-mujma' 'alayh*) is of this kind, the one who denies it becomes a *kāfir*, and if not, he does not. They, too, do

not require that an explicit text (naṣṣ) exist for it, because many of the ḍarūriyyāt al-dīn are matters for which there is no explicit text."

Regarding Mercy to Animals and Needless Pain in Slaughter

‘Allāma Burhān al-Dīn Abu al-Ḥasan ‘Alī ibn Abī Bakr al-Marghīnānī al-Ḥanafī (raḥimahullāh, d. 593 AH) writes:

"وَهَذَا لِأَنَّ فِي جَمِيعِ ذَلِكَ وَفِي قَطْعِ الرَّأْسِ زِيَادَةً تَعْذِيبُ الْحَيَّوانَ بِلَا فَائِدَةٍ، وَهُوَ مِنْهُيٌّ عَنْهُ. وَالْحَاصِلُ: أَنَّ مَا فِيهِ زِيَادَةٌ إِيْلَامٍ لَا يَحْتَاجُ إِلَيْهِ فِي الزَّكَاةِ، مَكْرُوهٌ. وَيَكْرَهُ أَنْ يَجْرَ مَا يُرِيدُ ذَبْحَهُ بِرِجْلِهِ إِلَى الْمَذْبَحِ، وَأَنْ تُنْخَعِ الشَّاةُ قَبْلَ أَنْ تَبْرُدَ: يَعْنِي تَسْكُنَ مِنَ الْاضْطِرَابِ، وَبَعْدَهُ لَا أَلَمَ فَلَا يَكْرَهُ النُّخْعُ وَالسَّلْخُ، إِلَّا أَنَّ الْكَرَاهَةَ لِمَعْنَى زَائِدٍ وَهُوَ زِيَادَةُ الْأَلَمِ قَبْلَ الْمَذْبَحِ، أَوْ بَعْدَهُ، فَلَا يُوجِبُ التَّحْرِيمَ، فَلِهَذَا قَالَ: تُؤْكَلُ ذَيْمَتُهُ."

(*al-Hidāya fī Sharḥ Bidāyat al-Mubtadī*, Kitāb al-Dhabā’ih, Man Taḥillu Dhabīḥatuhu wa man lā Taḥill, 4/350. Dār Iḥyā’ al-Turāth al-‘Arabī, Beirut, Lebanon, 1st ed., 1425 AH / 2004 CE)

Translation:

"In all these cases, and in cutting off the head, there is needless additional suffering for the animal, and this has been forbidden. In short, any additional pain in slaughter that is not needed is makrūh.

It is also makrūh to drag the animal one means to slaughter to the place of slaughter by its leg, or to cut through the goat's neck (nakh‘) before it has stopped writhing. Once it has become still, there is no pain, so cutting the neck and skinning are then not makrūh. This dislike is due to an additional factor, namely the extra pain before or after slaughter, and so it does not entail prohibition. That is why he said: an animal slaughtered (in such a manner can) be eaten (it being primarily ḥalāl)."

This passage settles both points.

First: **causing an animal pain without reason is forbidden** and makrūh in the Sharī‘ah.

Second: Imām al-Marghīnānī (the author of al-Hidāya) himself states plainly that this dislike does not make the slaughtered animal ḥarām. In other words, **the command to show mercy to animals refines the manner of slaughter, it does not cancel the ruling of slaughter or its lawfulness.**

Qurbānī Is Not Waived for a Vegetarian or Vegan

The conditions for *qurbānī* i.e. the prescribed sacrifice offered on Eid-ul-Aḍḥā to be *wājib* (obligatory) are:

(i) being a Muslim, (ii) being a resident (*muqīm*), and (iii) possessing the required *niṣāb* (the minimum level of wealth that makes *qurbānī* obligatory).

(*Radd al-Muḥtār ‘alā al-Durr al-Mukhtār*, Kitāb al-Uḍḥiya, under his words: وَشَرَّاطُهَا, 6/312. Sharikat Maktabat wa Maṭba‘at Muṣṭafā al-Bābī al-Ḥalabī wa Awlādh, Egypt, 2nd ed., 1386 AH / 1966 CE)

Eating the meat is neither a condition of *qurbānī* nor necessary for its validity. The essential act of *qurbānī* is the prescribed sacrifice of the animal for the sake of Allah. The distribution and consumption of its meat are among its related purposes and benefits.

Therefore, a Muslim who is vegetarian or vegan for lawful reasons, as explained in the second case above, is not exempt from *qurbānī*. He need not eat the meat himself; he may give it to relatives and the poor.

Clearing Up Misconceptions (Izālatush Shubuhāt)

First misconception: "Sayyidunā ‘Umar (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu) forbade meat"

This *athar* (report) does exist, but it has a context.

Imām Mālik ibn Anas (raḥimahullāh, d. 179 AH) narrates, with his chain of transmission, from **Sayyidunā ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb** (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu):

"إِيَّاكُمْ وَاللَّحْمَ، فَإِنَّ لَهُ ضَرَاوَةً كَضَرَاوَةِ الْخَمْرِ."

(*Muwatṭa’ Mālik*, *riwāyat Yahyā*, ed. ‘Abd al-Bāqī, Kitāb Ṣifat al-Nabī ﷺ, Bāb mā Jā’a fī Akl al-Laḥm, ḥadīth no. 36, 2/935. Dār Iḥyā’ al-Turāth al-‘Arabī, Beirut, Lebanon, 1406 AH / 1985 CE)

Translation: "Beware of (too much) meat, for it becomes a craving, like the craving for wine."

Using this as an argument for vegetarianism is incorrect, for four reasons:

1. *Ḍarāwa* means a craving and becoming habituated. The statement restrains from excess and indulgence, not from meat itself. And to restrain someone from excess in a thing is itself an admission that the thing is permissible; with something ḥarām, there is no question of more or less at all.

2. ‘Allāmah Abū al-Walīd al-Bājī al-Mālikī (d. 474 AH) explains this narration in the same way. Sayyidunā ‘Umar's warning was **not a general ban on meat**. Rather, he was discouraging people from eating too much meat, making it a constant habit, and becoming too attached to a life of comfort and luxury. (*al-Muntaqā Sharḥ al-Muwattaʿ*, Kitāb al-Jāmiʿ, mā Jāʿa fī Akl al-Laḥm, 7/253, Maṭbaʿat al-Saʿāda, 1st ed., 1332 AH)
 3. In the report that comes directly after it in Imām Mālik's *Muwattaʿ*, Sayyidunā ‘Umar (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu) saw Sayyidunā Jābir (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu) carrying meat he had just bought. He did not tell him that eating it was wrong; he reminded him that **while there is nothing wrong with satisfying one's own desire, a person should also be mindful of his neighbour and any needy relatives**. (ibid., under ḥadīth no. 36, 2/936)
- Imām al-Bājī al-Mālikī (raḥimahullāh) also mentions that Sayyidunā ‘Umar's advice may have been **an administrative measure taken during a time of famine and hardship**. Measures of this kind are based on circumstances and are therefore temporary; they can change when circumstances change. (*Al-Muntaqā Sharḥ al-Muwattaʿ*, Kitāb al-Jāmiʿ, Mā Jāʿa fī Akl al-Laḥm, 7/253, Maṭbaʿat al-Saʿāda, 1st ed., 1332 AH.)
4. There is also an issue with the chain of this report. In the *Muwattaʿ*, it is narrated by Yaḥyā ibn Saʿīd from Sayyidunā ‘Umar (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu), although Yaḥyā ibn Saʿīd did not meet him. The chain is therefore **disconnected (munqaṭiʿ)**. Some later attempts were also made to trace the report back to the Prophet ﷺ, but the scholars of ḥadīth did not accept that attribution.

So, in its proper context, **this report is a reminder to avoid excess and maintain moderation. It should not be used as the basis for a permanent legal ruling.** (*Shuʿab al-Īmān*, *al-Faṣl al-Thānī fī Dhamm Kathrat al-Akl*, ḥadīth no. 5284, 7/461; *al-Tamhīd* by Ibn ‘Abd al-Barr, 2/464.)

Second misconception: "Eating meat was not the Holy Prophet's ﷺ habit"

The fact that no fire was lit in the household of the Holy Prophet ﷺ for months at a time reflects **zuhd (detachment from worldly comforts)**, not any particular view about, or prohibition of, a specific type of food. On the contrary, there are clear reports that the Prophet ﷺ ate meat. As mentioned earlier in the

ḥadīth of *al-Shamā'il*, he ﷺ liked the foreleg. Something that he ﷺ liked when it was available cannot be described as something he had abandoned.

Moreover, *hady* (the sacrificial animal offered during Ḥajj), *qurbānī* (the sacrifice offered on Eid-ul-Adḥā), *walīmah* (the wedding feast), and *'aqīqah* (the sacrifice offered on the occasion of a child's birth) all provide further evidence that lawful meat was not something the Prophet ﷺ prohibited or regarded as inherently undesirable.

Third misconception: "The Qur'ān has called animals communities like you, so we should not eat them"

The context of verse 38 of Sūrat al-An'ām is creation and resurrection: these too are creatures of Allah and will be gathered back to their Lord.

To conclude from this that animals and humans are equal in rights goes against the context. The very Book that contains this verse also contains the lawfulness of eating meat of ḥalāl livestock and the rulings on *hady* and *qurbānī*.

One verse of the Qur'ān should not be interpreted in a manner that conflicts with clear and definitive rulings established elsewhere in the same Qur'ān. This is not the approach of the people of knowledge.

Fourth Misconception: "Fatwas from scholars in Western and developed Muslim-minority countries allow Muslims to abstain from meat"

PETA (People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals), an animal-rights organisation, has cited a number of fatwas in support of vegetarianism among Muslims. However, when we read these fatwas in full, including their conditions and explanations the claim is misleading.

Some of the fatwas clearly state that **giving up meat should not be considered better, more rewarding, or a means of drawing closer to Allah.**

Some even compare such an attitude to the practice of Brahmins and monks.

Others state that a **Muslim may choose to be vegetarian, provided he does not consider meat ḥarām or believe that avoiding it is a religious virtue.**

Thus, **these fatwas allow a person to avoid meat as a personal choice; they do not establish that avoiding meat is religiously better or more virtuous.**

Quoting only the word “permissible” while leaving out the conditions attached to it can give an incomplete picture of the actual ruling.

A ruling should therefore be understood in its full context. It is not sound to select statements from different scholars simply because they appear to support a preferred view, while leaving aside the conditions and explanations given by those scholars.

Fifth Misconception: “Modern conditions, environmental concerns, and industrial slaughterhouses require responsible Muslims to avoid meat and animal products”

These concerns are important, but they are separate from the ruling on meat, milk, and eggs themselves.

Modern problems should be addressed by correcting the wrong practices themselves, not by changing the ruling on something that the Sharī‘ah has permitted.

The Sharī‘ah commands kindness towards animals. Keeping animals in cramped conditions, causing them unnecessary suffering during transport, leaving them hungry or thirsty, or causing needless pain during slaughter are already prohibited. Certain unnecessary practices in slaughter are specifically considered *makrūh*, as explained in the reference to *al-Hidāyah*.

Environmental concerns also call for responsible use of resources. **The Sharī‘ah forbids *isrāf* (extravagance and waste) and teaches moderation in the use and consumption of the blessings and resources of this world.** This means that wasteful or harmful practices should be reduced and resources should be used responsibly. However, these principles do not by themselves change the ruling of a food that Allah has made lawful. A concern about how something is produced, transported, or consumed must be addressed at the level of those practices; it does not make the lawful thing itself unlawful.

Therefore, the **Islamic solution is to correct these wrong practices: to observe *iḥsān* (kindness and excellence) in slaughter, avoid waste and harm, and practise moderation in eating.** The solution is **not to abandon meat altogether or declare its consumption inherently cruel or unethical.**

A wrong practice connected to something permissible does not make the permissible thing itself unlawful. For example, wrong customs at weddings do not make *nikāḥ* forbidden, and un-Islamic practices associated with shrines do not make visiting the graves of the righteous impermissible. Likewise, mistreatment of animals does not make meat, eggs, or other lawful animal products impermissible.

Summary of the Ruling

- 1. Giving up meat and animal foods because of personal preference, health, illness, financial hardship, or environmental concerns is *mubāḥ* (permissible).** Such a person is **not sinful**, and simply avoiding these foods does not make the action *makrūh* or contrary to the Sunnah.
- 2. Giving up meat and animal foods permanently while believing that this is an act of worship, *zuhd* (voluntary detachment from worldly comforts), or a way of gaining greater religious merit, falls under the meaning of *rabbāniyyah* (monasticism and religious renunciation).** Such an attitude is contrary to the Sunnah, and it is prohibited in the Sharīʿah.
- 3. The permissibility of ḥalāl meat and of the slaughter of livestock is established by definitive evidence and by the consensus (ijmāʿ) of the Ummah, and is among the ḍarūriyyāt al-dīn (matters of the religion known to every Muslim). So calling ḥalāl meat or animal foods ḥarām, or calling slaughter "cruelty and a crime", is kufr when the person knows that Islam has made it ḥalāl and his words have no sound meaning. He must repent and renew his faith, and if married, his *nikāḥ*.** This ruling is not applied to anyone without knowing his exact words and intention.
- 4. Preventing others from eating ḥalāl meat, or calling them sinful or unethical merely because they eat it, is impermissible.**
- 5. For a resident Muslim who possesses the required *niṣāb* (the minimum level of wealth that makes *qurbānī* obligatory), offering a prescribed sacrificial animal as *qurbānī* on Eid-ul-Aḍḥā is *wājib* (obligatory).** This remains the case even if he does not eat meat. He may

simply give the meat to relatives and the poor. What he cannot do is leave *qurbānī* itself.

6. **Causing an animal unnecessary pain, including needless suffering during slaughter, is prohibited, and certain unnecessary practices in slaughter are *makrūh*.** However, such wrongdoing does not by itself make the meat of an otherwise lawful animal *ḥarām*.
7. **Excessive consumption of meat, or of food in general, and becoming overly accustomed to it are discouraged.** Islam requires moderation. However, the command to be moderate is not evidence that meat should be abandoned altogether.

وَاللَّهُ تَعَالَى أَعْلَمُ بِالصَّوَابِ

And Allah تَعَالَى سبحانه knows best what is right.

16 Rabīʿ al-Thānī 1448 AH / 28 September 2026 CE

 

Written by:

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ENDORSEMENTS:

الْجَوَابُ صَحِيحٌ وَالْمُجِيبُ نَجِيحٌ

(The answer is correct, and the respondent is sound in his judgment.)



Dr. Muftī Muḥammad ‘Aṭā’ullāh an-Na‘īmī

Shaykh al-Ḥadīth, Jāmi‘at an-Nūr and Madrasah Anwār al-Qur‘ān
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الجوابُ صحيحٌ

(The answer is correct.)

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ

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لله درّ المجيب حيث أجاب وأجاد فيما أفاد، الجواب صحيح

"How excellent is the respondent, who has answered well and done justice to what he set out. The answer is correct."

Muftī Mahtāb Aḥmad Qamar al-Na‘īmī

Khādim al-Iftā', Fatāwā Markaz Tarbiyyat al-Iftā' (Pakistan)

الجوابُ صحيحٌ

(The answer is correct.)

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